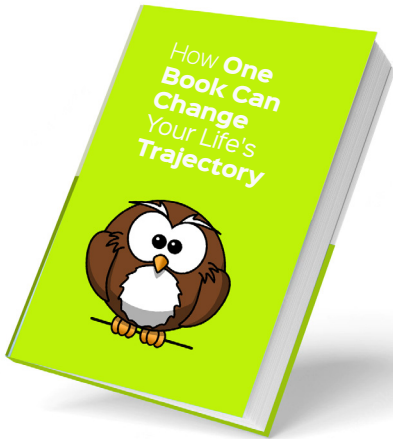


How One Book Can Change Your Life's Trajectory



An unexpected e-mail popped up in my mailbox the other day. It read: "You may or may not remember me. We interacted briefly several years ago. I am now trying to contact 'Thaths' Chandrasekhar of Netscape, and a Linux *guru*. The email ID that I have seems defunct. How can I contact him? Please help me." That email was from an intellectual who has great love for the open source world. Read on to know more about this veteran who says he is still learning.

For those who came in late, as the good ol' Phantom comics would say, Netscape (earlier Mozilla) was the American company that created an early, widely-used Internet browser.

In the early 1990s, a Goa University friend, Prof Gurunandan Bhat used this browser to demonstrate to us the first-ever pages we saw on the Internet. It seems like yesterday, but that was almost three decades ago.

To encounter the potential of this "online library on your desktop" was quite something then. But Netscape subsequently lost out to Internet Explorer. In turn, IE succumbed to ... and so the story goes on. But, at one point of time, Netscape indeed had a 90 per cent share of the browser market.

And that was where 'Thaths' worked.

Minor cult figures

During the early days of the Linux/ILUG campaigns across India (this was the late 1990s), the diaspora working in tech firms worldwide were treated as minor cult figures back home. Everyone looked up to them. Thaths was one such figure.

The mail mentioned above came from Prof Parthasarathy, better known

in the *desi* FOSS world of the 1990s as 'Doc Partha'. He was quick to say, then and now, "Call me Partha."

In a few days, Thaths was indeed found! But this search helped me to run across Dr Partha himself — after years. No, actually after two full decades. Doc Partha explained the context, and why the search came about: "I got my first book on Linux by begging for it. Thaths sent it to me." This mathematician with a PhD in the subject has focused for over two decades on promoting free and open source software (FOSS) computing.



Doc Partha, professor and Linux evangelist

In his time, he got known for his unique idea of 'Linux in a teaspoon'. "I never stopped; but became addicted to Linux. I'm what you would call a

Linux fanatic," he said in an interview with *OSFY* last month. He still sees proprietorial code as "untouchable". No biases, but just a policy for which he explains his rationale.

Says Doc Partha: "I wish to help my students discover mathematics and computer science." He lives in the city of Secunderabad, and adds with some pride: "I share my birthday with George Boole (mathematician, the father of Boolean algebra)."

Doc Partha has a background in discrete mathematics, graphics, graph theory, logic, cryptography, number theory and "everything related to the computer." In all of these fields, he says he finds "plenty of tools on Linux."

Some strong reasons...

There are strong reasons for this, of course.

The sharing system [in the FOSS world], the brotherhood, the fact that nobody's cheating nobody ... or that I'm not going to push something just to make money out of you — these are some of the "absolutely honest and clean" values of GNU/Linux which he finds amazing. "Honest and clean are the right words for Linux," says he.